AI-Powered Course Design: From OER Resources to Ready-to-Teach Courses

Two Workflows, One Approach

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Start Here: Choose Your Path

You can build course materials with AI whether or not you pay for a subscription. The thinking is the same on both paths. What changes is how much the tool can hold at once, so it changes how big each request should be.

	Workflow A: Paid tools	Workflow B: Free tools
Best for	Faculty with a paid Claude, ChatGPT, or Copilot plan	Anyone, including faculty using a free account or MCC's Copilot
Unit of work	A whole course, built unit by unit	One module, built one component at a time
What the AI holds	Full OER textbooks, a course outline, and standing instructions, saved in one workspace	A short module PDF and the pieces you paste in for each task
Your end product	A semester map, a unit template, and a full set of unit materials	One revised, ready-to-use module component, plus a process you can repeat
Watch out for	Errors that spread across many units if you don't catch them early	Message limits and new chats that forget earlier decisions

Not sure which you are? Start with Workflow B. Everything in it also works on a paid plan, and the habits carry over when you scale up.

Finding OER (Both Workflows)

Both workflows start with open materials. Begin with these two libraries.

Library	What it offers
OER Commons **oercommons.org**	A large, free library of open materials from around the world: textbooks, modules, activities, and assessments. Filter by subject, education level, and license. A free account lets you save, remix, and share.
OERTX **oertx.highered.texas.gov**	Texas's statewide OER repository from the Texas Higher Education Coordinating Board. Collections for Texas Core, co-requisite, and career and technical courses, with 15,000+ resources available through a free account. Built with ISKME, the team behind OER Commons, so the search will feel familiar.

Also worth a look: OpenStax, the Open Textbook Library, and MERLOT. MCC librarians can help with any of these.

How to search

Standard search	AI-assisted search
Start broad: your discipline plus “textbook” or “module.”	Describe the outcome and your students. Ask what kinds of OER to look for.
Narrow with the course outcome or topic.	Ask for search terms and topics, not final sources.
Add “OER,” “open textbook,” or “Creative Commons.”	Use a tool that cites sources, such as Perplexity, and open every link.
Use the site's filters: subject, level, license.	Run the AI's search terms on OER Commons and OERTX.
Search one site at a time with site: (for example, site:oertx.highered.texas.gov).	Verify every result yourself (see below).

Sample AI search prompt

Do this: Use this to brainstorm what to look for. Then search the libraries yourself.

Starter prompt

> I teach [course] to [describe students]. For the outcome [outcome], what kinds of open educational resources should I look for, and what search terms would find them on OER Commons and OERTX? Do not list specific titles unless you can link to them.

Before you use any OER, check four things: it exists at the original site, it carries an open license (Creative Commons or public domain), it is accurate, and it is accessible to your students. AI tools can suggest sources that do not exist or are not openly licensed.

The Six Moves (Both Workflows)

These six habits came from building INRW 0301 with AI. They work on every tool. The table shows how each move looks on each path.

Move	Paid: whole course	Free: one module
1. Set context once	Save audience, tone, and standards as Project instructions. Every chat in the Project inherits them.	Write a short context block and save it in a document. Paste it at the top of every new chat.
2. Assess before you build	Ask for a first-pass semester map you will refine together. It invites the AI to flag open questions.	Ask the AI to review your module and flag gaps. Tell it not to rewrite anything yet.
3. Correct with a reason	Say what is wrong and why. The reason helps the AI fix related content in other units too.	Say what is wrong and why. Keep corrections in your decisions log so the next chat starts with them.
4. Ask for reasoning	Invite the AI to push back on your plan, then decide for yourself.	Same. Ask for two or three options with pros and cons, then pick one.
5. Decide before building	Ask what needs deciding first, then answer in a numbered list.	Name the OER and the one component you need before you ask for a draft.
6. Keep it OER	Upload the textbook and send the AI back to it before it suggests outside material.	Find the OER, check it yourself, and paste in only the excerpt the AI needs.

The rule under every move: you make the decisions. The AI drafts, flags, and suggests. You approve, correct, and check.

Workflow A: Paid Tools — Build the Whole Course

Paid plans can hold full textbooks and keep standing instructions in a saved workspace, such as a Claude Project. That lets you work at the course level. The risk is scale: one wrong assumption can show up in every unit, so review early and often.

Step 1 Set up your workspace

Do this: Create a Project. Upload your OER textbooks and any course outline or program requirements. Write standing instructions that describe your students, your tone, and your non-negotiables.

Why: You will never have to repeat the basics, and every draft starts from the same standards.

Starter prompt

> You are creating course materials for [course] at a Texas community college. Students are [describe placement, background, and needs]. All materials should be [clear and direct / your tone]. [Name any teaching principles, such as growth mindset.] Use only the uploaded OER textbooks unless I approve another source.

Step 2 Ask for a first-pass course map

Do this: Request the full semester structure: weeks, units, readings, major assignments, and a repeating weekly pattern. Say clearly that this is a first draft.

Why: A draft you can react to is faster than a blank page. Asking for open questions surfaces decisions early.

Starter prompt

> Using the uploaded materials, draft a [number]-week curriculum map for an online version of this course. Each unit should follow the same structure: [list parts]. This is a first pass we will refine together. At the end, list the decisions you made that I should confirm.

Step 3 Correct the map before building anything else

Do this: Read the map against your program's expectations. Fix each problem with a short, specific correction that includes your reason.

Why: Every later document builds on this map. A correction here saves rework in every unit.

Starter prompt

> [Unit or item] is too much for these students because [reason]. Replace it with [what you want]. Update anything else in the map that depended on it.

Step 4 Build one unit as your template

Do this: Ask for complete materials for Unit 1 only: assignment sheets, rubrics, and instructor notes. Refine it until you would hand it to a colleague.

Why: An approved unit becomes the pattern. Every later unit is faster and more consistent.

Starter prompt

> Build the Unit 1 assignment sheets and rubrics. Before you build, ask me about anything you would otherwise have to assume, such as grading weights or who will use the materials.

Step 5 Build the remaining units one at a time

Do this: Attach or reference the approved template. Ask what needs deciding before each unit, answer in a numbered list, then approve each unit before starting the next.

Why: Going one unit at a time keeps errors small and easy to catch.

Starter prompt

> Here is the approved Unit 1 template. Before building Unit [n], list the decisions we need to make, with your recommendation for each. Do not build until I answer.

Step 6 Ask for a change summary on every revision

Do this: Whenever you request changes, ask the AI to list exactly what it changed.

Why: You can review a short list in a minute instead of rereading a whole document.

Starter prompt

> Make these changes: [list]. When you share the new version, include a short list of every change you made and where.

Step 7 Verify and load

Do this: Run each unit through four questions: Accurate (is every claim and fact correct?), Aligned (does it serve the learning objective?), Appropriate (is the tone right for your students?), and Coherent (does it fit the rest of the course?). Check every page reference, reading, and link against the actual textbook. Then load materials into Brightspace and check navigation, accessibility, and settings there.

Why: AI can cite a page or title that does not exist. Final quality is your call, not the tool's.

Workflow B: Free Tools — Build One Module at a Time

Free plans usually limit file size, message count, and how much a chat remembers. Do not expect a free tool to build or review a complete course in one request. Instead, work on one module and one component at a time. Two small habits keep this manageable: a saved context block and a running decisions log.

Before you start: prepare two files

- **Module PDF:** one module's learning outcomes, instructional content, assignment instructions, and rubric, combined into a single PDF. Keep it short. Skip the Brightspace export.
- **Context and decisions log:** a plain document with your context block at the top and a running list of decisions underneath. You paste this into each new chat.

Step 1 Give context

Do this: Open a new chat. Paste your context block, then attach the module PDF.

Why: Free tools often do not save standing instructions. Pasting the same block every time gives you consistent results.

Starter prompt

> Context: I teach [course] at a Texas community college. My students are [describe]. Materials should be [tone]. I use OER only. Keep these decisions in mind: [paste your decisions log].

Step 2 Assess the module

Do this: Ask the AI to review alignment, missing explanations, and likely points of student confusion. Tell it not to rewrite anything yet.

Why: You decide what needs work before any content is generated.

Starter prompt

> Review the attached module as an instructional design partner. Identify its learning outcomes, explain how the activities and assessment support those outcomes, and flag gaps or unclear instructions. Cite specific passages. Do not rewrite it yet. Ask me about anything you need rather than assuming.

Step 3 Identify OER needs

Do this: Ask what readings, examples, or practice activities would close the gaps you agreed on. Pick one need to work on.

Why: Naming the need first keeps the AI from producing material you will not use.

Starter prompt

> Based on the gaps we identified, what readings, examples, or practice activities does this module need? List three options with the outcome each supports. Do not draft anything yet.

Step 4 Find and verify the OER yourself

Do this: Use the AI's suggestions as search ideas, then locate the actual resource on OER Commons, OERTX, or another library (see Finding OER). Check it for accuracy, fit, accessibility, and an open license. Copy only the excerpt you need.

Why: Free tools may suggest sources that do not exist or are not openly licensed. Checking them is part of the skill, and short excerpts fit within free limits.

Step 5 Build one component

Do this: Paste the verified excerpt and ask for a single component: a reading guide, a discussion prompt, a practice activity, or assignment directions.

Why: One component fits comfortably in a free chat and gives you something you can use next week.

Starter prompt

> Using the attached module and the verified OER excerpt below, draft one practice activity that prepares students for the module's assignment. Identify the learning outcome it supports, write clear student-facing instructions, and list what I should check before using it. [Paste excerpt]

Step 6 Review and revise

Do this: Run the draft through four questions: Accurate (is every claim and fact correct?), Aligned (does it serve the learning objective?), Appropriate (is the tone right for your students?), and Coherent (does it fit the rest of the module?). Correct it with reasons and revise it for your students.

Why: Your judgment is what makes the component fit your course.

Starter prompt

> Compare this draft with the module's outcomes and rubric. Where does it miss or overreach? Then revise it: [your corrections and reasons].

Step 7 Log decisions and carry them forward

Do this: Add every decision you made to your log. When a chat gets long or you hit a limit, start a new chat with the updated context block and log.

Why: The log is your memory. It lets a fresh chat pick up where the last one stopped, even on a different tool.

Step 8 Finish in Brightspace

Do this: Build the final student experience in Brightspace. Check navigation, accessibility, links, and activity settings.

Why: The AI drafts content. Brightspace is where students actually meet it.

In Today's Session

Everyone leaves with a usable piece of their course and a process they can repeat.

If you have…	Use…	Today, aim to…
A paid plan and a whole course to redesign	Workflow A, Steps 1–2	Set up your workspace and get a first-pass course map
A paid plan and one module to improve	Workflow B on your paid tool	Finish one component, then try Workflow A after the session
A free account or MCC's Copilot	Workflow B, Steps 1–6	Finish one component and start your decisions log

A repeatable process for any tool

Give context → Assess the need → Select and verify sources → Generate a draft → Apply your judgment